

This dog.

1/9

■ THE FACTS One sheet each — print it again for the second...

Name _____

Called, actually _____

Born or about _____ Came home _____

Breed, or best guess _____

Colour and markings _____

Neutered _____ Grown weight _____

■ THE NUMBERS YOU CANNOT LOOK UP IN A HURRY

Microchip number _____

Chip registered with _____

Insurance, and policy number _____

Registered at (practice) _____

Licence or council registration _____

The chip gets them home tomorrow. The tag gets them home tonight.

A microchip needs a stranger to find a vet or a scanner, and it only works if the record attached to it is still yours — after a move, a new number, or a rehoming it very often is not. A tag is read by the person standing over your dog. Put your **mobile number** on it, not the dog's name, and check both once a year.

■ WHERE THEY CAME FROM

Breeder, rescue or found _____

Anything known about before _____

Same word. Same hand. Every time.

■ WHAT A STRANGER WOULD NEED TO KNOW

Good with _____

Not good with _____

What frightens them _____

What they guard, honestly _____

Where they sleep _____

Handled, lifted, collar grabbed? _____

How they ask to go out _____

How they ask to be left alone _____

■ THINGS THEY ALREADY DO THAT ARE THEIRS

■ IF THEY ARE EVER LOST

☐ Clear photograph taken this year, standing, side on

☐ A second one of the face, and of anything unusual

☐ Stored somewhere other than your phone

☐ Tag on the collar says a number that still works

■ OTHER ANIMALS IN THE HOUSE

WHO	HOW THEY GET ON
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____

Numbers, and when to use them.

Date _____

2/9

■ THE PRACTICE

Vet _____

Daytime number _____

Address _____

■ OUT OF HOURS — USUALLY SOMEWHERE ELSE

Who covers nights _____

Number _____

Address, and how long it takes _____

■ ALSO WORTH HAVING

Insurance claim line _____

Microchip company _____

Animal poisons helpline _____

Whoever has a spare key _____

Photograph this page once it is filled in

The moment you need the out-of-hours number is the moment you cannot find the folder. Fill it in, take a picture of it on your phone, and put the paper copy on the fridge rather than in a drawer. Tell the person who walks the dog where it is.

■ GETTING THERE

Worked out once, not at midnight

Who drives, if it is 3am _____

How long _____

Dog's weight _____

Can you lift this dog alone? Who helps? _____

■ PHONE NOW, DO NOT WAIT UNTIL MORNING

☐ Belly swollen and tight, trying to be sick and bringing nothing up, pacing — deep-chested dogs especially. Hours matter.

☐ Overheated: panting hard, staggering, gums brick red or very pale. Start cooling, phone on the way.

☐ A fit lasting more than a few minutes, or one after another without waking up between

☐ Eaten chocolate, sugar-free gum or sweets, grapes, raisins, or any human medicine — phone with the packet in your hand

☐ Swallowed a ball, a sock, a corn cob, a stick or a bone

☐ Hit by a car, a bad fall, or a fight — even if they get straight up

☐ Gums pale, white or blue, collapse, or a belly that swells after an accident

☐ Straining and producing nothing, or not able to pass water

This list is the short version of what emergency vets ask people to come in for. It is not a diagnosis and it is not complete. A dog that seems wrong to you is a good enough reason to phone — you know this animal and they do not.

■ ANYTHING ELSE TO WATCH FOR, FOR THIS DOG

The year of care.

Date 3/9

■ ROUTINE CARE — Intervals vary — the vet decides

WHAT, AND HOW OFTEN	LAST	DUE	DONE
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Vaccination booster Yearly, kennels will ask			☐
Worming Every 3 months, more if they scavenge			☐
Lungworm cover Check the product covers it			☐
Flea and tick Monthly, check the label			☐
Full check-up Yearly, twice once they are older			☐
Teeth looked at At the check-up			☐
Nails checked Clicking on the floor is too long			☐
Weighed Monthly, page 5			☐
Microchip details checked Yearly, and after moving			☐
Insurance and licence renewed Diary it before it lapses			☐

■ ANYTHING ONGOING — Medication, a condition, a diet

WHAT	DOSE AND WHEN	REPEAT
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		☐
		☐
		☐

■ APPOINTMENTS MADE

WHAT FOR	WHEN	BEEN
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		☐
		☐
		☐

■ KEEP OUT OF REACH — The short list, and the reason

Chocolate	The darker and the smaller the dog, the worse. Keep the wrapper.
Xylitol / birch sugar	Sugar-free gum, sweets, some peanut butter. Fast collapse.
Grapes, raisins, sultanas	Including mince pies and fruit loaf. No known safe amount.
Human painkillers	Ibuprofen and paracetamol. Never guess a dose.
Cooked bones, corn cobs	Bones splinter; a cob is the classic blockage.
Onion, garlic, leek	Cooked or raw, including in gravy and stock.
Antifreeze, slug pellets	Sweet, and lethal in small amounts. Check the shed.

If something has been eaten, phone before you wait to see. Take the packet with you — how much, how strong and how long ago are the three things you will be asked, and a guess is worth less than a wrapper.

■ WHERE THE RECORDS LIVE

Vaccination card

Insurance documents

Food or medicine from

■ COST OF THE YEAR

Insurance Food

Vet Everything else

■ WORTH ASKING AT THE NEXT CHECK-UP

☐ Is this weight right for this dog?

☐ Do the teeth need doing?

☐ Is the worm and flea routine still the right one?

☐ Anything to expect at this age or in this breed?

Out.

Date _____

4/9

The sniffing is the walk

A dog reads the lamp post the way you read your phone, and twenty minutes of being allowed to do it properly will settle a dog that an hour of marching will not. Let the lead go slack and let them choose where to stop. A ball thrown a hundred times is exercise, but it is also the same joint, the same skid and the same adrenaline a hundred times — it is a part of the week, not the whole of it.

■ THE WEEK

Off = off the lead · Sniff = let to choose

DAY	WHERE WE WENT	MINS	OFF	SNIFF
Mon	_____	_____	☐	☐
Tue	_____	_____	☐	☐
Wed	_____	_____	☐	☐
Thu	_____	_____	☐	☐
Fri	_____	_____	☐	☐
Sat	_____	_____	☐	☐
Sun	_____	_____	☐	☐

■ HOW THE WEEK WENT

■ WHAT THIS DOG NEEDS IN A DAY

- Not the breed book

Walking _____ Sniffing _____
 Training _____ Sleep _____

■ WHERE THEY CAN BE OFF THE LEAD

■ WHERE THEY ABSOLUTELY CANNOT

Livestock, ro...

Heat, and the five-second rule

Press the back of your hand to the pavement and hold it there. If you cannot keep it for five seconds, they cannot walk on it. Walk early or late, take water, and skip it altogether on the hot days — a missed walk costs you nothing. Flat-faced, heavy, old and black-coated dogs overheat first, and a car in the shade with a window open is still a car.

■ THE LONG LINE

How recall is practised before it is trust...

☐ A long line on a harness, never on a collar

☐ Paid every single time they come, at first

☐ Called only for something they want

☐ Let go again after coming — or coming ends the fun

■ REST DAYS, AND AFTER

More sleep than you think

Food, and the waistline.

Date 5/9

■ WHAT THEY EAT Weighed on scales, not scooped

WHAT	HOW MUCH	WHEN
------	----------	------

■ TREATS A tenth of the day, taken out of the meal

■ NEVER, FOR THIS DOG An allergy, a diet, or a firm no

☐

☐

☐

■ CHANGING FOOD Over a week, mixed in

☐

☐

Felt with your hands, not judged by eye

Run your fingers flat along the ribs: they should feel like the back of your hand with the fingers spread — there, under a little cover, without pressing. Look down from above for a waist, and from the side for a tuck. Most of us cannot see the extra kilo on our own dog, which is exactly why the column beside this one is worth filling in.

■ WHO ELSE FEEDS THIS DOG Everyone counts

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■ WEIGHT, SAME SCALES, SAME WEEK Kilos or pounds

MONTH	WEIGHT	WHAT ELSE YOU NOTICED
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January		
February		
March		
April		
May		
June		
July		
August		
September		
October		
November		
December		

■ IDEAL WEIGHT, IF THE VET HAS GIVEN ONE

Ideal Told on

A dog kept lean stays sound for longer, moves better for longer, and asks less of hips and knees that already have a hard job. Gaining a kilo a year is invisible; twelve rows of numbers are not.

Same word.

A dog cannot learn a word that keeps changing

If it is “come” from you, “here” from the children and the dog’s name shouted twice from the garden, that is three words for one thing and none of them means anything yet. Agree on one word each, write it here, and put the page on the fridge so the whole house is teaching the same lesson.

■ **THE WORDS WE USE** — And the hand that goes with it

WHAT WE ASK	THE WORD	THE HAND SIGNAL
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Come back		
Sit		
Down		
Wait / stay		
Leave it		
Drop it		
Off the furniture		
Bed / settle		
Good — the marker		
Free, you can go		

■ **NEVER USED AS A PUNISHMENT** — Or it stops working

- ☐ The recall word — coming back is always worth it
- ☐ Their bed, or their crate
- ☐ Their name on its own

■ **FIVE MINUTES, THREE TIMES A DAY** Short beats l...

DAY	WHAT WE PRACTISED	1	2	3
Mon		☐	☐	☐
Tue		☐	☐	☐
Wed		☐	☐	☐
Thu		☐	☐	☐
Fri		☐	☐	☐
Sat		☐	☐	☐
Sun		☐	☐	☐

■ **WHAT WE ARE WORKING ON NOW** One thing at a ti...

THE THING	STARTED	WHERE WE ARE

■ **WHAT ACTUALLY PAYS THIS DOG** — Not always food

- 1
- 2
- 3

■ **RULES THE HOUSE HAS AGREED** Sofa, beds, doorw...

Hands on.

Date 7/9

■ **ONCE A WEEK, THE SAME WAY ROUND** — In your lap

WHAT, AND WHAT TO FEEL FOR

	DONE	NOTICED
--	------	---------

Ears
Smell, redness, head shaking

☐	
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Eyes
Clear, no squinting

☐	
--------------------------	--

Teeth and gums
Pink, no tartar line, breath

☐	
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Nails
No clicking on hard floors

☐	
--------------------------	--

Feet and pads
Between the toes, grass seeds

☐	
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Coat and skin
Part it — scurf, hot spots

☐	
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Along the body
Both hands, slowly, for lumps

☐	
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Bottom and tail
Scooting, soreness, anything caught

☐	
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Ticks
After every walk in long grass

☐	
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Why a dog that is handled every week is easier at the vet

Ears looked in, paws held, mouth opened, tail lifted — done at home, in your lap, for nothing more than a piece of chicken. A dog who has had all of that a hundred times does not need holding down for it on a table. It is also how you find the lump in the week it appears rather than the month it is obvious.

■ **GROOMING** — Coat type decides everything here

Brushed	Bathed
Clipped	Nails

Groomer, and number

■ **TEETH** — The only thing that really works is daily

☐ Dog toothpaste only — human paste can contain xylitol

☐ Lift the lip and do the outside; that is where it forms

☐ A few seconds daily beats a scrub once a month

☐ Nothing so hard you would not hit your own knee with it

■ **LUMPS, BUMPS AND ANYTHING NEW** — Where, how ...

DATE	WHERE ON THE BODY	SIZE	VET
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐

Measure it against something — a pea, a grape, a coin — and write the date. Whether a lump is changing is the question that gets asked, and it is not one anybody can answer from memory.

■ **WHAT THEY HATE HAVING DONE, AND HOW WE MA**

While we are away.

Date 8/9

THE BASICS

Dog Dates

Us, and the best number

If you cannot reach us

Vet, and out-of-hours (page 2)

Insurance policy number

Kennel or sitter, and number

FEEDING Amounts, not "a bit"

WHAT	HOW MUCH	WHEN
------	----------	------

MEDICATION, IF ANY

WHAT	DOSE AND WHEN	GIVEN
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THE WALKS Where, how long, and on what

Not off the lead. Not for the first week.

A dog with perfect recall at home has no recall at all in a strange field with the person they are worried about. Keep them on a lead or a long line, check the tag says a number that will be answered while we are away, and if there is any chance of a slip lead being needed, it is on the hook by the door.

WHERE EVERYTHING IS

WHAT	WHERE
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Food, and the scoop or scales

Lead, harness, long line

Poo bags

Towels

Bed and favourite toy

Spare key

PLEASE DO, AND PLEASE DO NOT

☐

☐

☐

☐

MESSAGE US IF

DATE _____

WHAT YOU NOTICED

TOLD
VET

Slow to get up after a lie-down. Drinking more. Off the stairs, or off the sofa they always get on. Licking one paw. Scratching one ear. Eating more slowly, or turning the head to chew. A lump that feels different. None of these is an emergency on the day, and all of them are the sort of thing a vet asks “how long has that been going on?” about — and this page is how you answer.